

Baby bones

Newborn babies have soft bones. Their bones are mostly made of cartilage, a tough, rubbery material that gradually becomes hard. In this X-ray of a child's hand, you can see the areas of cartilage where, later, bones will grow.

The bones in your hand are all linked together by muscles, tendons, and ligaments.

Cartilage

There are 27 small bones in your hand.

Bones fit together like a jigsaw puzzle.

Bone work

You have three kinds of bones—long bones such as those in your legs, short bones such as those in your hand and spine, and flat bones such as your shoulder and skull. Bones are linked by different kinds of joints, which allow them to move in different ways.

Your thumb is special. It has a saddle joint in it which allows you to move your thumb in two directions.

You have flat gliding joints in your foot.

Your kneecap, or patella, protects your knee.

The shoulder has a ball-and-socket joint. The round end of one bone fits into a cup-shaped hole in the other. Your shoulder can move in a complete circle.

Your knee joint, like your elbow, is a hinge joint. The end of one bone fits into a sort of hollow in the other. This kind of joint will only bend in one direction.